

The Making and Knowing Project: An Open-Access Digital Edition and Translation of a sixteenth-century Artist's Manuscript (BnF Ms. Fr. 640)

Director: Pamela H. Smith, Seth Low Professor of History, Director of the [Center for Science and Society](#), Columbia University

1180 Amsterdam Ave., Fayerweather 605, MC 2516, New York, NY 100278

Email: ps2270@columbia.edu Phone: 212-854-7662

The [Making and Knowing Project](#) is a five-year initiative to create an open-access critical digital edition of [an intriguing late sixteenth-century French manuscript](#), Bibliothèque nationale de France Ms. Fr. 640. This anonymous manuscript is the written result of actual workshop practice in the late sixteenth century, and it gives unique insight into craft and artistic techniques, daily life in the sixteenth century, and material and intellectual understandings of the natural world. This 170-folio manuscript includes recipes for processes from drawing-instruction, to pigment- and dye-making, metal-coloring, counterfeit gem production, canon-casting, tree-grafting, land-surveying, a form of taxidermy for manufacturing curiosities in the form of composite animals (e.g., kittens and bats), making paper maché masks, and much more.

The Making and Knowing Project will produce a critical digital edition and English translation of this little known and completely unstudied manuscript by a series of “expert crowd sourcing” workshops and courses that involve students, practitioners (such as sculptors and painters), scholars of the humanities and social sciences (history, art history, anthropology, and museum scholars), natural scientists (chemists, conservation scientists, and engineers), and practitioner-scholars from the emerging field of the digital humanities. The first stage of transcription and translation of the manuscript is carried out in a series of three-week summer paleography workshops that bring together graduate students (of, for example, French literature, history, and art history) to gain skills in middle French script by transcribing and translating the manuscript. The first two paleography workshops were held June 2014 and June 2015, during which 15-16 students (a different group each year) from European and North American universities transcribed and translated almost half of the manuscript each year (concentrating on metalworking recipes in 2014 and color making recipes in 2015). The next workshop, which will combine paleography training, text encoding, and an introduction to data visualization techniques, will be June 2016.

The second phase of the project, the Laboratory Seminar, began September 2014. In the Laboratory Seminar (Columbia History course “G8906: Craft and Science”), students (up to 12 different students per semester) conduct historical and laboratory research on the recipes transcribed and translated by the paleography workshop. Laboratory research focuses on attempting to understand materials and processes appearing in the manuscript by means of a variety of techniques, including experimental

reconstructions of the processes described in the recipes. The student research is brought together in multi-media essays that form the historical and material annotations for the critical edition of the manuscript. This course is offered every semester for at least three years.

The third phase of the project occurred for the first time in May 2015, when a Working Group Meeting brought together scholars, practitioners, and the students from the 2014-15 Craft and Science classes to discuss and critique the annotations authored by the students on moldmaking and metalworking recipes. This phase provides expert oversight on the critical edition. Three more Working Group Meetings are planned at the end of each of the coming years of work on the project.

Additional components of the project include a summer digital encoding workshop in the penultimate year to provide collective completion and correction of encoding the manuscript, and a Digital Laboratory Seminar in which computer science students will help develop the final environment for the critical edition and translation of the manuscript. The “go live” date for the digital edition is 2019.

The production of this critical edition is an experiment in combining pedagogy and original research, and involves students working alongside historians, scientists, conservators, and experienced makers in a laboratory. As such, this project involves unusual cooperation between scientists, artists, and practitioners of the humanities. In addition, the project involves numerous collaborators. The activities take place primarily at Columbia University, but research and teaching collaborations with the art conservation departments of the University of Amsterdam and Glasgow University began in January 2015, when students engaged in experiments and research to produce six additional annotations for the critical edition. In addition, the Making and Knowing Project Columbia University team also collaborated with students at Bard Graduate Center and the V&A PhD programme in the History of Design, as well as pursued institutional collaboration with the Max-Planck-Institute for the History of Science in Berlin.

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